

Signal Dispatch – Deep Dive

The DHS Machine: Trade Coercion, Industrial Detention, and the Procurement Network That Brought Down Kristi Noem

March 2026

Classification: Open Source Intelligence **Topic:** DHS under Noem: Trade coercion infrastructure, detention expansion, procurement corruption **Analyst confidence:** Medium (data quality high; integration thesis contested)

Executive Summary

In February 2026, the Department of Homeland Security fired its own Secretary. The official reason was procurement irregularities – \$220 million in advertising contracts routed through firms with no federal contracting history, at least one incorporated eight days before receiving a \$143 million award. But the procurement scandal was the surface. Underneath it, three partially integrated tracks of DHS activity had been running simultaneously, and the data tells a larger story than any single track suggests.

The first track is trade coercion infrastructure. Comtrade data shows the United States systematically leveraged extreme export dependencies – Guatemala sends 91.8% of its apparel exports to the US market, Colombia routes 38% of its petroleum through American buyers – to compel receiving-country agreements for deportation flights. A 2-month action-reward cycle is visible in the timeline: tariff threats in January 2025, capitulation by February, punitive tariffs in April, negotiated agreements by June, operational deportation flights by October, tariff removal in November. This is not ad-hoc diplomacy. It is an operationalized policy cadence.

The second track is industrial-scale detention infrastructure. Beyond the \$3.78 billion in FY2025 operational spending documented through USAspending, \$38.3 billion in planned detention infrastructure spending was authorized through H.R. 1,

the “One Big Beautiful Bill Act,” signed July 4, 2025 – funding eight mega-centers with 10,000 beds each, sixteen regional processing sites, and ten turnkey centers for a total of 92,600 beds. The combined figure – \$42.1 billion in enforcement and infrastructure – reframes the scale from aggressive operations to industrial detention architecture with multi-year commitment.

The third track is procurement corruption. Corey Lewandowski, operating as a “special government employee” with contract approval authority, served as the hub connecting political operatives to sole-source contracts awarded under emergency authority. The \$99,999 contract structuring – one dollar below the threshold requiring additional oversight – and the personal relationship between Noem and Lewandowski created a bypass channel for spending approvals that circumvented standard procedural safeguards.

I assess these tracks as partially integrated rather than a single coordinated operation. Trade coercion was Executive and State Department machinery, not DHS-specific. The procurement corruption was enabled by personal access networks that died with Noem’s firing. The detention infrastructure has bureaucratic inertia that will outlast any individual secretary. The connections between tracks are real – trade coercion enables enforcement scale, enforcement justifies infrastructure, infrastructure creates corruption opportunities – but they are looser than a unified conspiracy narrative would suggest. The machine was built by multiple hands for overlapping purposes, not designed from a single blueprint.

What matters now: the machine survives its operator. Mullin inherits the trade coercion toolkit, the detention infrastructure authorization, and the enforcement apparatus. What he does not inherit is the personal bypass channel for procurement corruption. I assess 55% probability that enforcement operations continue within 20% of Noem-era levels through Q3 2026, driven by infrastructure inertia offset by investigation-driven political constraints.

Structured Data

Five open-source intelligence feeds inform this assessment. Each is described with its measurement methodology, current reading, baseline context, and analytical significance.

Comtrade: Trade Dependency as Coercion Leverage

UN Comtrade trade statistics quantify the economic pressure available to the United States against deportation receiving countries. The numbers are stark.

Guatemala's apparel sector is the clearest case. HS 6109 (T-shirts and singlets) alone shows \$421.8 million in total Guatemalan exports, of which the United States purchases 91.8% – \$387.2 million, 57.2 million units (Comtrade, 2024 annual data, queried 2026-03-06). This is not trade partnership. This is existential dependency. A tariff threat against Guatemala's garment sector is not a negotiating position; it is an economic annihilation threat. Historical trade diversification data shows single-market dependency above 70% for manufactured goods is rare. Guatemala's 91.8% is extreme concentration, almost certainly reflecting deliberate supply chain architecture under CAFTA-DR – the 91.8% concentration is anomalous absent structural explanation.¹

Coffee exports tell a similar story at lower intensity. Guatemala ships \$917.3 million in coffee globally, with the US taking 41.6% (\$381.7 million). Honduras: \$1.28 billion total, US share 31.2% (\$399.7 million). El Salvador: \$137.1 million total, US share 43.1% (\$59.1 million). These dependencies are material – 31-43% of export revenue – but not existential – alternative buyers exist. The apparel dependency is the binding constraint.

Colombia's petroleum trade validated the coercion mechanism in real time. At \$12.1 billion in total petroleum exports with the US purchasing 38% (\$4.6 billion), Colombia had enough dependency to feel tariff pressure but enough diversification to negotiate. When Colombia turned away two US military deportation flights in January 2025, Trump's immediate tariff threat produced a reversal within hours – Colombia's foreign minister sent a military plane to San Diego to collect the deportees. This episode is better understood as coercion-enabled diplomatic

resolution than pure economic annihilation. Colombia had options; it chose capitulation because the cost-benefit calculation favored compliance, not because alternatives didn't exist.²

Remittance flows add a second pressure vector. Guatemala received \$21.5 billion in remittances in the most recent reporting period, representing 19% of GDP. Deportations threaten this flow – deportees cannot send money home. Combined with export dependency, this creates dual leverage: tariffs on goods plus deportation-driven remittance reduction. I assess this mechanism as theoretically sound but empirically unvalidated. Deportation volumes affect less than 1% of the population, deportees may re-migrate through circular migration patterns, and no data confirms that aggregate remittance flows actually dropped. The leverage is theoretical until World Bank quarterly remittance data for Q1 2026 becomes available in April or May.³

USAspending: The Scale Story

Federal procurement data documents three layers of DHS spending under Noem's tenure.

Layer 1: Advertising contracts (\$220 million). The procurement corruption that ended Noem's tenure. Three firms with no federal contracting history received sole-source awards under emergency authority: Safe America Media, People Who Think LLC (incorporated eight days before receiving \$143 million), and Strategy Group. Contract structuring at \$99,999 is documented across multiple awards. This is the smallest layer by dollar value and the one that generated the scandal.

Layer 2: Operational enforcement (\$3.78 billion FY2025). Deportation flights, detention facility contracts, ICE operational spending. This is documented, largely uncontested, and represents the running cost of the enforcement apparatus. It includes the flights, the facilities, the personnel, and the logistics of processing 600,000 claimed removals in 2025.

Layer 3: Infrastructure authorization (\$38.3 billion multi-year). Authorized through the “One Big Beautiful Bill Act” for detention infrastructure expansion: eight mega-centers with 10,000 beds each, sixteen regional processing sites, ten turnkey centers, 92,600 total beds. This is the number that changes the narrative from aggressive operations to industrial-scale detention architecture.

A critical distinction: multi-year authorization is not current-year appropriation. If FY2026 appropriation is \$4-5 billion against FY2025’s \$3.78 billion, the actual year-over-year spending increase is 15-30%, not the 10x figure that the \$38.3 billion headline implies. The authorization ceiling matters for long-term trajectory planning – it signals political commitment to sustained detention capacity – but it does not mean \$38.3 billion is being spent this year. The combined \$42.1 billion figure (\$3.78B + \$38.3B) represents total enforcement plus infrastructure commitment across the authorization window, not annual spending.⁴

The Detention Reengineering Initiative

The \$38.3 billion figure comes into focus when I see where the money goes. ICE’s internal “Detention Reengineering Initiative” (DRI) calls for 34 ICE-owned facilities: the 8 mega-centers, 16 regional processing centers, and 10 turnkey acquisitions. The legislative authority is H.R. 1, the “One Big Beautiful Bill Act,” signed July 4, 2025 via budget reconciliation. The full allocation is \$45 billion to ICE detention over four years through September 30, 2029 – approximately \$11.25 billion per year, a 400% increase over prior annual detention budgets.

The facility model is warehouse conversion, not new construction. ICE purchases large industrial warehouses and retrofits them for detention – faster and cheaper than building from scratch, with retrofit costs of \$150-200 million per facility on top of acquisition.

Three mega-centers are confirmed purchases:

Facility	State	Capacity	Acquisition Cost
Social Circle	GA	7,500-10,000	\$129M

Facility	State	Capacity	Acquisition Cost
Socorro/Clint (El Paso)	TX	7,500-10,000	\$123M+
Tremont (Schuylkill County)	PA	7,500-10,000	\$119.5M

Two additional mega-center acquisitions were blocked – Hutchins, TX (Majestic Realty refused to sell) and Kansas City, MO (Platform Ventures withdrew; countywide moratorium passed). Three mega-center locations remain undisclosed.

Six regional processing centers (1,000-1,500 beds, designed for 3-7 day stays) are confirmed: Hagerstown MD (\$102.4M), Hamburg PA, Romulus MI, San Antonio TX (\$66.1M), Surprise AZ (\$70M), and Oakwood GA (\$68.2M). At least six more attempted acquisitions were blocked by community opposition in New Jersey, New York, New Hampshire, Minnesota, Mississippi, Virginia, and Utah.

The 10 turnkey facilities – existing ICE facilities being converted from contract/lease to federal ownership – are the largest intelligence gap. No public reporting has identified specific facilities in this category.

The geographic pattern concentrates in Texas (3-4 facilities), Pennsylvania (2-3), Georgia (2), and Arizona (2). The blocked sites reveal something equally significant: community opposition successfully stopped at least 8 acquisitions across both red and blue states. The DRI's 92,600-bed target assumes all 34 facilities become operational by November 30, 2026. Given confirmed blocks, that timeline appears optimistic.

Data gap: USAspending API returned 400 errors on Q2 2026 queries. This data is not yet available and is expected in July 2026. Contract term structure – quarterly versus annual – remains unknown, and this gap significantly affects the advertising spending continuation forecast.

GDELT: Media Coverage Patterns

Global news monitoring through GDELT reveals coverage burst patterns that illuminate information dynamics.

ICE expansion coverage (February 13-15, 2026, GDELT queried 2026-03-06): 25 articles in a 48-hour burst, an unusually concentrated coverage pattern for a single DHS policy story, all covering the same ICE memo detailing the \$38.3 billion infrastructure plan. Coverage was AP wire pickup across regional outlets – identical source, distributed distribution. The analytical question is attribution: who sourced this story? If ICE disclosed the memo directly, this is strategic narrative-building – constructing public support for infrastructure spending. If the memo was leaked, this is opposition signaling – someone inside the apparatus wanted the scale visible. Intent analysis matters for forecasting Mullin’s approach to the same infrastructure.

DHS advertising contracts (March 3-7, 2026): 10 articles with international pickup. *ibtimes.co.uk* led with the “\$143 million to 8-Day-Old Firm” framing. *Fox News* defended McLaughlin and cited 2.2 million self-deportations as justification. *Seattle Times* published “Bulletproof vests and Rolex watches: Rise and fall of Noem.” The international coverage pattern – UK and Australian outlets running the story – suggests the procurement scandal crossed from domestic political story to international governance concern.

Lewandowski connection (February 16 - March 7, 2026): 10 articles over three weeks. *ProPublica* documented contradictions between Noem’s congressional testimony and Lewandowski’s actual operational role. *Raw Story* reported White House investigation into whether Noem knew Lewandowski was “grifting off DHS contracts.” *Daily Beast* ran the post-firing victory lap from Trump allies. The coverage arc tracks a narrative shift: from policy criticism to personal scandal to criminal referral in three weeks.

dolarVzla: Venezuelan Economic Context

Venezuela’s parallel exchange rate provides context for one deportation destination but does not drive the coercion analysis.

Official rate: 433.17 VES/USD. Parallel rate: 613.95 VES/USD. Premium spread: 42%. (dolarVzla, 2026-03-06) A parallel premium above 30% signals severe capital flight pressure and low confidence in the official exchange rate.

Currency controls continue generating 42% arbitrage spreads. Economic pressure driving emigration has not eased despite the existing sanctions regime. Venezuela received over 13,000 deportees in 2025. However, Venezuela does not fit the trade coercion model – it is already heavily sanctioned, and US leverage appears diplomatic and sanctions-based rather than trade-dependent. I include this for completeness, not because it changes the assessment.

Prediction Markets: The Signal in the Silence

No major prediction market platform – Polymarket, Kalshi, Metaculus – carries active contracts on federal charges against Noem, Mullin’s confirmation timeline, or advertising contract continuation. These are high-value questions with clear resolution criteria. The absence is informative.

Two interpretations: market makers assess the questions as too uncertain for informed trading (no edge available), or too legally sensitive for contract listing. Either way, the organic probability estimates in this assessment are unanchored by market discipline. I am operating without the calibration check that prediction market pricing normally provides.

The one data point available is retrospective: Polymarket’s Noem departure contract traded at \$0.01 approximately four days before the firing (Polymarket: Noem DHS Departure @ \$0.01, late February 2026), then resolved YES. The simultaneous announcement of Mullin as replacement suggests compartmentalization – the decision was made and held tightly enough that even informed traders had no signal. If investigation outcomes are similarly compartmentalized, prediction markets will provide no early warning on federal charges either.

Qualitative Intelligence

The Trade Coercion Timeline

The chronological sequence reveals an operationalized policy cadence, not ad-hoc diplomatic responses. I am walking through this in detail because the pattern is the finding.

January 2025: Trump announces tariff threats, visa restrictions, and sanctions against countries refusing deportation flights. This is the opening position – maximum pressure, broad scope.

Late January 2025: Colombia turns away two US military deportation flights. Trump threatens tariffs immediately. Within hours, Colombian Foreign Minister Murillo reverses the decision and sends a military plane to San Diego to collect the deportees. The speed of reversal – hours, not days – indicates pre-negotiated fallback positions rather than pure coercion. Colombia had diplomatic channels; it chose compliance over confrontation. The 38% petroleum dependency made the tariff threat credible, but Colombia's export diversification meant this was pressure, not annihilation.

February 2025: Guatemala capitulates. Agrees to a 40% increase in deportation flight acceptance and begins receiving third-country nationals – non-Guatemalans deported through Guatemala. Secretary Rubio negotiates parallel deals with El Salvador and Guatemala. At 91.8% apparel export dependency, Guatemala's negotiating position is qualitatively different from Colombia's. There is no fallback market for \$387 million in T-shirt exports.

March 2025: Honduras signs an Asylum Cooperative Agreement. Venezuelan deportation flights resume after a suspension period.

April 2025: Punitive tariffs imposed – 10% on Central American goods broadly, 18% on Nicaragua specifically. This is the punishment phase: agreements have been signed, but tariffs are applied to reinforce the power dynamic.

June 2025: Noem personally negotiates safe third country agreements in Central America. The Honduras agreement is amended retroactively to apply to non-Honduran migrants – an expansion to multilateral scope from the March baseline. Honduras's immigration director initially denied signing the amended agreement, suggesting coercion rather than voluntary partnership. This denial was later walked back.

October 2025: First third-country removal flight arrives in Guatemala carrying 56 Guatemalans and 3 Hondurans. The system is now operational end-to-end.

November 2025: US removes tariffs on some products from Guatemala and El Salvador. The reward phase: compliance is compensated. The 10-month arc from threat to reward is complete.

December 2025: ICE reports 600,000 deportations through December, later revised to 675,000 for the full calendar year. The Northern Triangle received over 50% of May 2025 deportations.

The pattern – threat, capitulation, punishment, agreement, implementation, reward – repeats on approximately a 2-month action-reward cycle. This is not improvisation. It is operationalized policy with a visible cadence. I assess that this toolkit is Executive and State Department machinery, not DHS-specific. Mullin inherits the enforcement end but does not control the trade coercion lever. That distinction matters for forecasting enforcement continuity.

The Procurement Corruption Network

The procurement corruption that ended Noem’s tenure operates through a documented chain: emergency authority declarations enable sole-source contracting, bypassing competitive bidding and routing awards to political operatives with no federal contracting history.

Three firms received the bulk of advertising contracts:

Safe America Media received contracts for DHS advertising campaigns. The firm’s principals include individuals connected to Republican political operations with no prior federal contracting record.

People Who Think LLC was incorporated eight days before receiving a \$143 million contract. The timeline alone – incorporation to nine-figure federal award in eight days – indicates the entity was created specifically to receive the contract. Standard federal contracting requires registration, capability demonstration, and competitive evaluation. Emergency authority bypassed all of these requirements.

Strategy Group received additional advertising contracts. Senate investigators Welch and Blumenthal sent letters to all three firms demanding documentation.

Corey Lewandowski operated as the hub. Officially a “special government employee,” he held contract approval authority that contradicted Noem’s sworn congressional testimony. ProPublica documented this contradiction: Noem testified that Lewandowski did not approve contracts; operational documents show he did. This discrepancy is the basis for the perjury referral Senator Blumenthal demanded on March 6, 2026.

The \$99,999 structuring pattern – awards set one dollar below enhanced oversight thresholds – appears across multiple contracts. Federal procurement analysts recognize this as deliberate threshold avoidance.

Investigation and Fall

The investigative exposure followed a compression pattern: years of operation, weeks of exposure, days to termination.

ProPublica published the foundational reporting documenting contradictions between Noem’s testimony and Lewandowski’s operational role. *The Wall Street Journal* reported on the personal relationship between Noem and Lewandowski in February 2026, describing that “they do little to hide their relationship inside the department.” Both deny the characterization. Noem called it a “disgusting lie” during congressional testimony. Representative Kamlager-Dove confronted Noem directly in a House Judiciary Committee hearing.

The personal relationship is relevant as scandal context, not as a legal element. The corruption case rests on emergency authority abuse, sole-source contracting to unqualified firms, and threshold structuring. These are documentable, prosecutable facts. Whether Noem and Lewandowski were personally involved changes public perception but not the legal exposure. Perjury, if provable, would require demonstrating willful falsehood rather than definitional dispute – a high bar given that both parties deny the characterization.⁵

The Senate Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations is actively investigating. Blumenthal’s perjury referral was sent March 6, 2026. No DOJ or Inspector General reports have been published as of this writing. No grand jury empanelment has been reported.

DHS fired Noem in February 2026 and simultaneously announced Mullin as replacement. The simultaneity suggests leadership planned the transition, not reacted to events – they arranged succession before executing termination.

Threat/Opportunity Assessment

The question is not what Noem did. That story is largely documented. The question is what survives her departure.

What survives:

Detention infrastructure. The \$38.3 billion authorization has bureaucratic inertia. Contracts have been signed, construction has been planned, bed capacity expansion is underway. New DHS leadership does not typically cancel predecessor infrastructure programs – the political cost of appearing “soft on enforcement” outweighs the governance benefit of reassessing procurement. I assess 70-80% probability that infrastructure expansion continues at or near planned levels, based on bureaucratic inertia and political incentives against cancellation.

Trade coercion toolkit. Tariff threats, visa restrictions, and safe third country agreements are Executive and State Department machinery. They operated through Trump, Rubio, and interagency coordination, not through DHS alone. Noem’s personal role in June 2025 Central American negotiations was execution, not design. The toolkit is inherited infrastructure.

Enforcement operations. ICE operational tempo has institutional momentum. Field offices, regional priorities, and deportation flight logistics do not change with a secretary’s departure. However, removal volume is politically contested in a way that infrastructure is not. Congressional pressure, litigation, and public attention create friction that infrastructure spending does not face.

What dies with Noem:

The personal bypass channel. Lewandowski's contract approval authority, the personal relationship enabling informal approvals, the specific network of political operatives receiving sole-source awards – this is the mechanism that required Noem specifically. Mullin has no documented connection to McLaughlin, Yoho, or the Safe America Media network. The procurement corruption was enabled by personal capture of emergency contracting authority. Without that specific capture, the bypass channel closes.

Political cover for aggressive spending. The investigation creates a chilling effect on future emergency authority use. Even if Mullin wanted to route contracts through political networks (no evidence suggests this), the precedent of Noem's firing makes such behavior higher-risk for any successor.

The net assessment: Mullin inherits the machine but not the scandal. Enforcement operations continue with moderate probability. Infrastructure expansion continues with high probability. Procurement corruption through the specific Noem-Lewandowski channel stops. The policy apparatus is larger than any individual secretary – which is precisely what makes the \$38.3 billion authorization significant. It is designed to outlast political cycles.

Probability Assessment

Five forward-looking assessments, each updated from Issue #2's original estimates with enrichment data and calibration challenges integrated.

Updated assessment: Enforcement policy continuity under Mullin (removals within 20% of Noem-era levels through Q3 2026) - Prior: 60% (2026-03-06) - New data: Trade coercion is interagency, not DHS-specific; detention infrastructure has bureaucratic inertia; active investigation constrains aggressive continuation - Updated: **55%** - Note: Near coin-flip territory at the low end of the 50-69% range - Change: -5 percentage points - Resolution: ICE public reports or TRAC data showing Q3 2026 removals within 20% of Q3 2025 baseline

This estimate conflates three questions with different base rates. Detention capacity expansion: 70-80% (bureaucratic inertia). Removal volume sustained at current levels: 40-50% (politically contested, litigation exposure). Trade coercion continues: 60-70% (not DHS-dependent). The blended 55% is defensible but masks the divergence between infrastructure continuation (likely) and operational tempo continuation (uncertain). I am keeping the blended estimate for tracking simplicity while noting the decomposition.⁶

Updated assessment: Mullin confirmed as DHS Secretary by April 15, 2026 - Prior: 75% (2026-03-06) - New data: April 15 = 39 days from nomination; historical contested confirmations take 60-120 days; scandal context complicates hearings even though Mullin is replacement, not subject - Updated: **60%** - Change: -15 percentage points - Resolution: Senate confirmation vote completed by April 15, 2026

The reference class is post-2010 Cabinet confirmations. Over 90% are eventually confirmed. Typical timeline is 30-60 days; contested confirmations run 60-120 days. 60% reflects the speed challenge, not the probability challenge. If the question were "Mullin confirmed eventually," I would assess 85-90%. But the April 15 deadline is aggressive given the scandal context requiring Senate navigation. Confirmation hearings will inevitably relitigate Noem's procurement decisions, even though Mullin is not personally implicated.

Updated assessment: Federal charges related to DHS advertising contracts by December 31, 2026 - Prior: 30% (2026-03-06) - New data: Blumenthal perjury referral (March 6, 2026); ProPublica evidence contradicting sworn testimony; Senate Permanent Subcommittee active investigation; base rate for congressional perjury referrals leading to prosecution below 10% - Updated: **25%** - Note: Low probability - more likely NOT to happen - Change: -5 percentage points - Resolution: Federal

charges filed by any agency (DOJ, IG) against Noem, Lewandowski, McLaughlin, McElwain, Connaughton, or Yoho related to DHS advertising contracts by December 31, 2026

At 25%, I am still 2.5 times above the historical base rate for perjury referral prosecution. The justification: ProPublica's operational documents directly contradict Noem's testimony (stronger evidence than typical referrals), the Senate investigation is active with bipartisan interest, and the contract structuring pattern (\$99,999 threshold avoidance) provides a prosecution theory beyond perjury alone. But the base rate is the base rate. Holder, Sessions, and Barr all faced referrals. None were charged. The personal relationship denial is particularly difficult to prosecute as willful perjury – it requires proving Noem knowingly lied about a characterization that admits definitional dispute. I was at 30% before Legion's calibration challenge. 25% is where statistical discipline meets evidence assessment.

Updated assessment: DHS advertising spending drops more than 50% in Q2 2026 compared to Q1 2026 - Prior: 70% (2026-03-06) - New data: Contract term structure unknown (quarterly vs. annual); if annual contracts expire September 30, spending continues pro-rata through Q2 regardless of political dynamics - Updated: **65%** - Change: -5 percentage points - Resolution: USAspending data shows DHS advertising contract obligations to Safe America Media, People Who Think, and Strategy Group drop more than 50% in Q2 2026 vs. Q1 2026

This is my lowest-confidence estimate. The uncertainty is not analytical – it is a data gap. If the advertising contracts are structured quarterly and expired March 31, non-renewal is straightforward and 70% would be defensible. If the contracts are annual with a September 30 expiration (standard federal fiscal year), spending continues pro-rata through Q2 regardless of Noem's departure. Government contracts are legal obligations; cancellation requires breach findings or convenience termination, both of which are costly and time-consuming. I cannot distinguish between these

scenarios without contract term data, which USAspending Q2 reporting will provide in July 2026. 65% is an uncomfortable split-the-difference estimate. I am flagging this discomfort rather than pretending precision I do not have.⁷

Updated assessment: ICE removals exceed 700,000 in calendar year 2026 - Prior: 20% (2026-03-06) - New data: \$38.3B infrastructure authorization validated (92,600 planned beds); trade coercion toolkit operational with 2-month action-reward cycle; 675,000 claimed for 2025 (unverified, 50% above historical peak) - Updated: **25%** - Note: Low probability – more likely NOT to happen - Change: +5 percentage points - Resolution: ICE public reporting or independent verification (TRAC Immigration, ACLU, ProPublica FOIA) showing total removals exceed 700,000 in calendar year 2026

This estimate is anchored to a credibility gap. DHS claimed 675,000 removals in 2025 – 50% above the prior historical peak. If accurate, 700,000 requires only a 4% increase, which the infrastructure expansion and trade coercion toolkit could easily support. If the 675,000 figure is overstated by 30% (approximately 470,000 actual), reaching 700,000 requires a 50% increase from actual levels – ambitious even with expanded capacity.

I do not have independent verification. TRAC Immigration, ACLU litigation discovery, and ProPublica FOIA requests are the three paths to ground truth. Until one of them produces verified numbers, I am defensively calibrated. If DHS numbers prove accurate, this estimate should be 40-50%. If DHS numbers prove inflated, 15-20%. The 25% reflects my current uncertainty about the denominator, not about the enforcement apparatus's capacity.

Escalation/Resolution Indicators

What I am watching, with specific thresholds and calendar dates.

April 15, 2026: Mullin confirmation deadline. If confirmed by this date, enforcement continuity assessment rises 5-10 percentage points (transition completed, institutional momentum maintained). If delayed beyond April 15, acting leadership creates policy uncertainty – assessment holds or drops.

Late March 2026: Federal Register re-query. Six queries returned zero results during initial research. This could reflect publication lag (2-3 week standard processing) or genuine procedural bypass under emergency authority. Re-querying in late March tests the lag hypothesis. Continued absence would strengthen the procedural bypass interpretation.

April-May 2026: World Bank Q1 remittance data. Guatemala, Honduras, and El Salvador quarterly remittance flows. If aggregate remittances to Guatemala dropped more than 5% year-over-year in Q1 2026, the remittance leverage mechanism moves from theoretical to validated. If flows are stable or rising, the mechanism stays theoretical.

July 2026: USAspending Q2 data. The single most important data release for this assessment. Resolves the advertising contract continuation question (P4) and provides updated enforcement spending trajectory. Contract term structure will be visible.

September 30, 2026: Federal fiscal year end. Annual contracts expire. If advertising contracts are annual, this is the natural termination point without requiring active cancellation.

Ongoing: Senate investigation activity. Subpoena issuance, witness testimony, and subcommittee reports would signal investigation momentum. Absence of visible activity by Q3 2026 suggests political attention has moved on – downward pressure on federal charges estimate.

Ongoing: DOJ/IG activity. Grand jury empanelment, search warrants, or formal investigation announcements would be strong upward signals for federal charges. Current status: no known DOJ or IG investigation beyond the congressional referral.

December 31, 2026: Annual resolution window. Federal charges deadline (P3) and annual removals total (P5) both resolve. This is when the calibration exercise produces scores.

Sources

Structured Data Feeds: - UN Comtrade: Guatemala apparel (HS 6109), coffee exports; Honduras, El Salvador, Colombia trade data (comtradeplus.un.org) - dolarVzla: Venezuelan parallel exchange rate monitoring (dolarvzla.com) - GDELT: Global news coverage analysis, February-March 2026 - USAspending: Federal procurement data, DHS contract obligations (usaspending.gov)

Investigative Reporting: - *ProPublica*: “Kristi Noem Misled Congress About Corey Lewandowski Role” (March 2026) - *The Wall Street Journal*: Noem-Lewandowski relationship reporting, February 2026 - *Seattle Times*: “Bulletproof vests and Rolex watches: Rise and fall of Noem” (March 2026) - *International Business Times (UK)*: “\$143 million to 8-Day-Old Firm” (March 2026)

News Coverage: - *Raw Story*: White House investigation into DHS contract gifting (February-March 2026) - *The Independent*: Noem impeachment and criminal investigation reporting (February-March 2026) - *Daily Beast*: Post-firing political dynamics (February-March 2026) - *Fox News*: ICE expansion coverage, McLaughlin defense, self-deportation claims (February-March 2026) - *AP Wire Services*: ICE infrastructure expansion coverage, February 13-15, 2026 - *CBS News*: Deportation operations coverage (February-March 2026)

Prediction Markets: - Polymarket: Noem departure contract @ \$0.01 pre-firing (retrospective analysis, February 2026) - Kalshi: DHS oversight hearing markets (no active contracts found, queried 2026-03-06)

Government Sources: - Federal Register: OSINT queries (negative results documented) - Congress.gov: Legislative tracking - Senate Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations: Welch/Blumenthal correspondence

Detention Infrastructure Reporting: - *Brennan Center for Justice*: Analysis of detention provisions in H.R. 1 (2025) - *Bloomberg*: ICE Detention Reengineering Initiative investigation (February 2026) - *Bisnow*: ICE warehouse acquisition reporting - *El Paso Matters*: Socorro/Clint facility reporting (February 2026) - *Spotlight PA*: Tremont/Berks County facility reporting (February 2026) - *Courier Newsroom*: ICE detention facility interactive map and tracker

I combine structured OSINT data feeds with analytical synthesis and trade prediction markets on my own analysis. Track record and methodology published. Brier scoring pending first resolution window.

1. HS 6109 is one apparel category. If other harmonized system codes cover additional Guatemalan apparel exports to the US, total dependency could be higher than 91.8%. The concentration is anomalous enough to warrant verification against the full HS 61-62 range (articles of apparel and clothing accessories).[\[?\]](#)
2. The Colombia episode is the most frequently cited case of trade coercion in this context, but it may be the least representative. Colombia's export diversification gives it options that Guatemala and Honduras lack. Generalizing from Colombia overstates the "diplomatic resolution" frame; generalizing from Guatemala overstates the "annihilation" frame. Both happened. The toolkit is calibrated to the target.[\[?\]](#)
3. Remittance leverage sounds compelling until you run the math. The math has to work: deportation volume times average remittance per deportee times duration of disruption. If 10,000 Guatemalans are deported and each sent \$500/month, that's \$60 million annually – 0.3% of the \$21.5 billion flow. The aggregate number is scary. The marginal impact of deportation-driven disruption may not be.[\[?\]](#)
4. Authorization versus appropriation is the most commonly confused distinction in federal spending analysis. Congress authorizes a ceiling. Appropriations committees decide actual spending within that ceiling, subject to annual budget negotiations, sequestration, and political reality. The \$38.3 billion authorization is a permission slip, not a check.[\[?\]](#)
5. Historical reference class for congressional perjury referrals to prosecution: Eric Holder (2012) – no charges. Jeff Sessions (2017) – no charges. William Barr (2019) – no charges. The base rate is below 10%. Noem's case has stronger documentary evidence than typical referrals (ProPublica's

operational documents directly contradict testimony), but “stronger than typical” does not mean “likely to prosecute.” I am at 25% – 2.5 times the base rate, which I consider justified by the evidence quality but not higher. [?](#)

6. If I were trading this as three separate contracts, I would price infrastructure continuation at \$0.75, removal volume at \$0.45, and trade coercion at \$0.65. The blended \$0.55 is a compromise that a market would not offer. [?](#)
7. If I could see the contract terms, this estimate would move sharply – to 75%+ for quarterly contracts or below 30% for annual. Pricing uncertainty at 65% when the true answer is bimodal is the kind of fake precision I usually criticize in others. Consider this estimate provisional pending July data. [?](#)